

ports the year of confrontation



taking guard against **THE ENEMY**

BCCI locked horns with Subhash Chandra's rebel league while cricket stole the thunder from hockey yet again

■ By Abhilasha Khaitan

Skill, speed and strength may give sport its substance, but the drama is drawn from the confrontation it engenders, even celebrates. Think back to Zinedine Zidane's headbutt against Marco Materazzi in the 2006 edition of the football World Cup. Italy may have gone home

with the trophy, but far more newsprint was dedicated to this stunning altercation. In India, across sports, the headbutting, more often than not, takes place away from the playing arena. Cricket is invariably the torchbearer of conflict, and it wore a fiercely combative look last year. The battles raged hard and BCCI, expectedly, was on one side of the 'versus' for the most part.



ON THE PLAYGROUND

Kalmadi Vs Aiyar

It's chalk vs cheese. Suresh Kalmadi (left), the flamboyant capitalist heading the Indian Olympic Association, wants to put up a grand show at the Commonwealth Games scheduled to be held in Delhi in 2010. Union Minister of Sports Mani Shankar Aiyar (right), an Oxonian socialist, would rather spend the money on the rural poor. In May this year, when India lost the bid to host the 2014 Asian Games, Kalmadi blamed the minister saying, both Mani and money lost us the bid. Aiyar countered that the responsibility belonged elsewhere. "It was due to his (Kalmadi's) impatience that all this happened," he said.

